Subject Heading Changes in Bibliographic Records

H 165

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A. Background

Subject headings in an existing bibliographic record may be changed or corrected when an error has been discovered in the record, when an established subject heading is being changed, or a new subject heading is being established. This instruction sheet provides guidelines addressed to Library of Congress catalogers only for determining what to correct and what not to correct, and procedures for correcting records online in the catalog or for reporting records that are candidates for correction to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division. It replaces D 240 and parts of D 243, instruction sheets that were formerly in the *Subject Cataloging Manual: General Cataloging Procedures*.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Textbooks***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Updated procedural information. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Errors: For the context of this instruction sheet, errors include incorrect spelling, incorrect content designation, typographical mistakes, as well as obsolete, unauthorized, or inappropriate subject headings for the resource described.

D. What to correct

D.1. Errors

Correct spelling, typographical, and content designation errors in subject headings, as well as obsolete, unauthorized, or inappropriate subject headings. Focus on correcting only genuine errors. Avoid second guessing another cataloger's judgment or updating records that were cataloged in another era with different cataloging practices, so long as the headings use the currently authorized term. (See sec. D.2 below) For example, a subject heading in an old bibliographic record that uses a form subdivision is not an error, as it was correct for cataloging policy at the time of cataloging.

Note: Errors in existing records may be corrected at any time, either online in the LC ILS or by reporting them to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division, using the Database Maintenance Request Form at https://staff.loc.gov/sites/aba/2022/12/21/database-maintenance-request-form/

An error that occurs in only one or a few bibliographic records is usually more efficiently corrected by the cataloger online at the time the error is discovered. An error that occurs in a large number of records is more efficiently corrected by reporting it to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division.

D.2. Revising existing subject headings

When an existing subject heading is being revised, all bibliographic records that contain the old form of the heading must be updated to the new form.

Do not change these bibliographic records online in the LC ILS before the subject heading change proposal has been submitted to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division (PTCP) for inclusion on a tentative list and been approved. Instead, report these records as candidates for correction when submitting the proposal, using one of the methods described in sec. G, below. After the proposal has been approved, the changes are made by PTCP.

D.3. Establishing new subject headings

When a new heading is being established, search the bibliographic database to locate existing bibliographic records for which the new heading is appropriate. In some cases, the existing subject heading or headings will be deleted and the new heading substituted. In other cases, the existing headings will be retained and the new heading added.

Do not change these bibliographic records online in the LC ILS before the new subject heading proposal has been submitted to PTCP for inclusion on a tentative list and been approved. Instead, report these records as candidates for correction when submitting the proposal, using one of the methods described in sec. G, below. After the proposal has been approved, the changes are made by PTCP.

D.4. MARC vs. PREMARC records

Do not discriminate between MARC and PREMARC records with respect to subject heading corrections. Correct errors and add newly proposed headings to bibliographic records regardless of whether they are MARC or PREMARC records. When updating a subject heading on a PREMARC record to a currently valid form, delete the legend [from old catalog] if it appears beside the heading.

D.5. Genre/form terms

Correct terms in 655 fields if they are coded as *Library of Congress Subject Headings* or *Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms for Library and Archival Materials* (LCGFT). LC subject headings have 0 in the second indicator position. LCGFT terms are coded as:

Model:

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655 #7 $a [Term] $2 lcgft
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Do not change genre/form terms coded in other ways.

Note: The use of LCSH is not recommended for genre/form fields; LCGFT is to be preferred for new bibliographic records. Generally, do not make changes to existing records that include LCSH terms in the 655.

E. What not to correct

E.1. Children's literature headings

Generally, do not make changes in children's literature headings. These headings are maintained by the children's literature catalogers.

Note: Children's literature headings are identifiable by the presence of 1 in the second indicator position of the 6XX fields.

E.2. Non-LC headings

Do not change non-LC headings such as National Library of Medicine headings or French language headings assigned by Canadian libraries.

Note: Non-LC headings are identifiable by the presence of values in the range of 2-6 in the second indicator position of the 6XX fields, and also by second indicator 7 of the 6XX fields when the corresponding $2 subfield value is not lcgft.

F. Correcting records online in the LC ILS.

To correct a record that has an error of the type described in sec. D.1, above, proceed as follows:

- Check that the legend in the 906 $g subfield begins with y-.
- If it begins with n-, do not correct the record.

Note: If the 906 $g subfield has the legend n-oclcserc, the record is a serial record that may be corrected using OCLC software. The corrected record will be automatically imported into the LC ILS, usually on the day after the correction was made.

- Check that the 040 field has subfield $d DLC in the final position. If it does not, add it. If the record is still in the CIP stage, follow the standard procedure for applying the code "rix" or "rip" in the 906 $b subfield, as described in DCM M3.3.2.2.2., Notification of CIP pre-publication changes.
- Correct the text of the 6XX field(s) as necessary.
- Save the corrected record and validate it.

G. Reporting candidate records for correction to the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs Division

If an error occurs in a large number of bibliographic records, or if records need to be corrected or updated in connection with a subject heading proposal that has not yet been approved,

report the candidate records to PTCP for correction rather than correcting them online yourself. Use one of the following methods to report the records, as appropriate:

- Database Maintenance Request. Use the Database Maintenance Request Form at https://staff.loc.gov/sites/aba/2022/12/21/database-maintenance-request-form/
    - Do not use this method if the corrections are being made in connection with a subject heading proposal that is being submitted and has not yet been approved. Instead, use one of the alternative methods listed below.
- Printouts of records. Make a printout of each individual record to be corrected and manually mark it up with the changes that are to be made. Indicate clearly if any of the existing headings are to be changed or deleted and any new heading(s) to be added. If the position of a new heading is significant (for example, if the new heading should be the first subject heading in the record), indicate this clearly. If a new heading is to be assigned with topical, geographic, or chronological subdivisions, show the complete string.
    - This method is recommended only if the number of records to be changed is small.
- Lists of LCCNs. If an identical change is to be made to a group of records, submit a list of the LCCNs of those records, together with clearly written instructions describing the change to be made to each record in the list.
    - This method is recommended if the number of records to be changed is relatively large and the list of LCCNs can be easily assembled. It is also recommended when the changes are being submitted along with one or more subject proposals. In the latter situation, the LCCNs should be listed in the body of the email (Cf. H 200 sec. 19).
- Printout or PDF of search. Submit a screen printout that shows the search that was done to retrieve the candidate records, together with clearly written instructions describing the change to be made to each record retrieved by the search. If the printout displays any individual records that should not be changed, cross them off.
    - This method is recommended if the number of records to be changed is relatively large and the candidate records can easily be retrieved by doing a single search.
    - If the changes are being submitted along with one or more subject proposals, a PDF that shows the search may be attached to the email (Cf. H 200 sec. G). The body of the email should include clearly written instructions describing the change to be made to each record. If the PDF shows any records that should not be changed, indicate that in the body of the email.

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.